

Top 10 High-Leverage Relievers in the 2027 Draft Class

Projecting future relievers is often easier than projecting future starters.

The role rewards extremes. Premium velocity, dominant breaking balls, unusual release characteristics, and the ability to generate outs in the most important moments can often matter more than repertoire depth or the ability to navigate a lineup three times. Many of the best professional relievers succeed because they possess one or two weapons so overwhelming that hitters know exactly what is coming and still cannot do anything about it. The 2027 class contains an unusually strong collection of these profiles.

Some of the pitchers on this list began their college careers in the bullpen and already look comfortable in leverage situations. Others possess starter aspirations but have arsenals that may ultimately become even more impactful in shorter bursts. In several cases, the difference between a future starter and a future reliever is extraordinarily small. A fourth pitch, a slight improvement in command, or the ability to maintain effectiveness deeper into games could completely change the projection.

For this exercise, the focus is not on overall prospect value or draft position. Instead, the question is simple: If the game starts in the 9th inning and a professional team needs three outs, which pitchers would I trust most? Or hitting closer to home for the '27 season, who do you want coming out of the pen on a June night in Omaha?

Velocity matters. Swing-and-miss matters. The ability to neutralize hitters from both sides of the plate matters. Above all else, elite weapons and projection matter.

These are the 10 pitchers from the 2027 class I would bet on most heavily to impact a professional bullpen.

Number 10: Tyler Guerin, RHP, Iowa

2026 Stats: 7.49 ERA | 51.2 IP | 1.819 WHIP | 42 K | 35 BB | 1.20 K:BB

Guerin earns the final spot on this list because the profile becomes significantly more attractive when viewed through a relief lens. The statistical performance was inconsistent throughout 2026, but the raw ingredients remain intriguing. At 6-foot-6 with a low arm slot, a power sinker, and a hard gyro slider, he creates uncomfortable looks that are easier to envision playing in shorter bursts than over a full starter's workload.

The sinker is the foundation of the arsenal. Sitting in the low-to-mid 90s and featuring nearly 19 inches of arm-side movement, the pitch creates difficult angles and significant horizontal action from his lower release point. The movement profile gives hitters problems when located properly, particularly when he trusts the sinker's natural run rather than trying to guide it to the edges of the plate. In shorter appearances, the pitch has a chance to play closer to its raw traits because he would not need to pace himself or navigate lineups multiple times.

The slider is the pitch that pushes the profile onto this list. While the shape is more gyro-oriented than sweep-heavy, the pitch possesses enough velocity and depth to generate chase when located beneath the zone. The fastball-slider combination already resembles that of many professional bullpen arms, and the movement contrast between the two pitches creates uncomfortable swing decisions despite command inconsistency.

The biggest obstacle remains strike throwing. Guerin's delivery creates deception, but it also creates timing issues that lead to walks and hit batters. A relief role would lessen the burden on the command and allow the pure stuff to play more aggressively.

Why #10: Guerin makes the list because high-leverage relievers often succeed on one dominant fastball shape and one quality breaking ball. The command questions are real, but the sinker-slider pairing gives him a realistic pathway toward a professional bullpen role if the strike throwing improves even modestly.

Number 9: Anderson Nance, RHP, NC State

2026 Stats: 4.70 ERA | 53.2 IP | 1.528 WHIP | 61 K | 25 BB | 2.44 K:BB

Nance lands on this list because the profile already resembles a professional bullpen arm. While the command remains inconsistent, the raw ingredients are difficult to ignore. A riding fastball, two distinct breaking balls, and the ability to generate swing-and-miss with each offering give him multiple ways to attack hitters in shorter appearances. Unlike many reliever profiles that lean heavily on a single pitch, Nance has several legitimate weapons capable of missing bats.

The sweeper is the carrying pitch and the reason he fits so naturally into a leverage role. The shape creates significant horizontal movement while maintaining enough depth to avoid becoming a one-dimensional offering. Against left-handed hitters in particular, the pitch consistently generated uncomfortable swing decisions and could be landed for strikes or expanded beneath the zone when ahead in the count. Few pitchers this far down the list possess a secondary offering with this much pure movement.

The fastball and harder slider elevate the profile further. The fastball already flashes above-average traits and plays particularly well when elevated, while the slider provides a firmer look capable of generating chase against right-handed hitters. Together, the three pitches create enough movement diversity that hitters cannot simply eliminate one shape or velocity band from consideration.

The primary obstacle is strike throwing. Nance's delivery can become difficult to repeat, leading to stretches where the command disappears and counts become unfavorable. In a rotation that issue becomes difficult to manage. In a bullpen and single inning role, the stuff can be allowed to play more aggressively while minimizing exposure to longer outings and repeated lineup turns.

Why #9: Nance ranks here because high-leverage relievers are often built on bat-missing traits more than workload certainty. The command remains a work in progress, but the fastball, slider, and sweeper give him the type of arsenal that professional organizations routinely trust in late innings. If the strike throwing improves even modestly, he has the tools to move quickly through a pro bullpen.

Number 8: Lazaro Collera, RHP, Miami

2026 Stats: 4.99 ERA | 70.1 IP | 1.379 WHIP | 70 K | 31 BB | 2.26 K:BB

Collera earns a place on this list because he already possesses the type of carrying pitch professional bullpens are built around. While much of his collegiate career has been spent in a starting role, the underlying traits suggest his arsenal could become even more impactful in shorter outings. The profile is centered on one of the better sweepers in the class, supported by a quality fastball and an above-average changeup that gives him multiple ways to attack hitters.

The sweeper drives the projection. Unlike many sweepers that rely almost entirely on horizontal movement, Collera's combines substantial glove-side movement with plus depth. The result is a pitch that remains difficult to track even when hitters identify it early. Throughout 2026, the pitch generated a 35% whiff rate, limited opponents to a .167 batting average, and produced a 34.9% CSW. More importantly, the swing-and-miss was concentrated in predictable leverage locations, consistently finishing down and glove-side where professional relievers generate their best results.

The fastball helps the sweeper play up. Collera already demonstrates a clear understanding of how to sequence the two pitches together, forcing hitters to account for both velocity and movement before asking them to adjust to the sweeper's shape. The changeup further strengthens the profile by providing a viable weapon against opposite-handed hitters, reducing the likelihood that major league clubs view him as a strict platoon reliever.

What makes Collera particularly interesting in a bullpen context is how concentrated the value becomes. As a starter, he is required to spread usage across multiple offerings and navigate lineups several times. In relief, he could lean heavily into the sweeper-fastball combination and allow his best attributes to play more aggressively. Many successful professional relievers are built around one elite secondary. Collera already possesses that pitch.

Why #8: Collera ranks here because elite breaking balls routinely create bullpen value, and his sweeper already performs like a professional out pitch. The pitchers ranked above him either possess louder raw stuff or more obvious leverage roles, but few arms in the class have a single pitch capable of driving high-leverage success as effectively as Collera's sweeper.

Number 7: Kyle Alivo, RHP, Iowa

2026 Stats: 3.48 ERA | 51.2 IP | 1.374 WHIP | 67 K | 24 BB | 2.79 K:BB

Alivo earns this ranking because few pitchers in the class possess his combination of athleticism, pitch diversity, and relief upside. A former two-way player, he entered college with less pitching experience than many of the names on this list, yet still showed flashes of a professional arsenal during his freshman campaign. The profile remains raw, but the pure pitch quality gives him multiple pathways to becoming an impactful bullpen arm.

The most encouraging aspect of the profile is the sheer volume of quality shapes. Alivo deployed seven distinct pitches during the season, a reflection of both his athleticism and relative inexperience on the mound. While the variety can occasionally work against him by blurring the lines between certain breaking-ball shapes, it also gives him multiple weapons capable of missing bats. The curveball emerged as the best of the group, flashing plus traits with elite spin, significant depth, and enough sweep to consistently create uncomfortable swings.

The fastball further raises the ceiling. Sitting in the mid-90s with quality ride, plus extension, and a lower release height, the pitch already grades as an above-average professional offering. Combined with the breaking-ball depth, it creates the type of fastball-breaking ball pairing that often thrives in shorter outings. The sweeper and cutter provide additional avenues for attack, while the sinker gives him another movement profile that can be leveraged against opposite-handed hitters.

What keeps Alivo from ranking higher is overall refinement. The command remains inconsistent, several of the breaking balls blend together at times, and the changeup currently offers very little value. There is still a significant amount of pitch development ahead. Unlike some of the pitchers above him, the profile is not yet streamlined.

Why #7: Alivo ranks here because of the upside created by his athleticism and pitch quality. While several pitchers below him possess cleaner present profiles, few can match the combination of velocity, spin, and pitch diversity. In a bullpen role, where the best two or three pitches can be emphasized, the ceiling becomes particularly intriguing.

Number 6: Walker McDuffie, RHP, UNC

2026 Stats: 3.63 ERA | 72.0 IP | 1.375 WHIP | 89 K | 43 BB

McDuffie lands in the middle of this list because his profile already resembles many successful professional multi-inning relievers. At just 5-foot-11, he does not fit the traditional starter mold, but he compensates with deception, movement diversity, and one of the better sweepers in the ACC. While his 2026 statistical step backward raised some questions about starter viability, it also highlighted just how valuable the sinker-sweeper combination can be in shorter, high-leverage outings.

The sweeper is the defining pitch in the arsenal and the primary reason McDuffie appears here. Featuring elite spin and significant horizontal movement, the pitch consistently generated swing-and-miss against right-handed hitters while maintaining enough depth to avoid becoming a one-dimensional offering. More importantly, he showed the ability to repeatedly locate it beneath the zone and along the outer edge, allowing the movement profile to play at maximum effectiveness. The pitch already looks capable of missing bats against professional hitters.

The sinker complements the sweeper exceptionally well. While the pitch lacks the raw power of some fastballs ranked elsewhere in the series, the movement profile and release characteristics create uncomfortable east-west angles that keep hitters from getting comfortable. Together, the sinker and sweeper form a two-pitch foundation that many professional relievers would gladly build around.

The changeup is what separates McDuffie from a traditional bullpen projection. The pitch flashed enough quality against left-handed hitters to suggest there may still be a pathway toward remaining in a rotation. Whether that ultimately happens is less important for this article than the fact that the offering gives him another viable lane to generate outs.

Why #6: McDuffie ranks here because elite sweepers tend to play in leverage, and few pitchers in the class pair a plus sweeper with a complementary sinker as effectively. Even if the starter profile never fully materializes, the combination of deception, movement, and swing-and-miss gives him a strong chance to impact a professional bullpen.

Number 5: Joshua Whritenour, RHP, Florida

2026 Stats: 3.13 ERA | 37.1 IP | 1.018 WHIP | 55 K | 17 BB | 3.24 K:BB

Whritenour ranks this highly because his profile already resembles that of a professional leverage reliever. The combination of upper-90s velocity, a firm power cutter, and a willingness to challenge hitters gives him one of the more direct pathways from college baseball to a professional bullpen. While there are still questions about overall role and arsenal depth, very few pitchers in the class can match the raw explosiveness of his primary weapons.

The fastball is the foundation of the profile. Sitting around 98 mph and touching triple digits, it combines premium velocity with enough ride and carry to consistently miss bats at the top of the zone. Unlike many power arms, the pitch is not simply hard. It possesses enough shape to remain effective beyond pure velocity and gives hitters very little margin for error. The ability to maintain that velocity while attacking aggressively in the strike zone makes it a legitimate carrying tool.

What elevates the bullpen projection is the cutter. Thrown around 91 mph, the pitch functions as a second fastball at times while creating enough late movement to force uncomfortable swing decisions. The velocity separation between the fastball and cutter is minimal, making it extremely difficult for hitters to differentiate between the two pitches until very late in flight. Together, they form one of the more difficult two-pitch combinations in the class to prepare for.

The primary question is whether a reliable third pitch ever emerges. The current profile does not necessarily need one to succeed in relief, but it remains an important consideration when discussing long-term roles. The fastball and cutter already provide enough quality to handle high-leverage situations and allow the best traits in the arsenal to play as often as possible.

Why #5: Whritenour ranks here because few pitchers in the class possess a better fastball-cutter combination. The pitchers ranked above him either offer more unique weapons or stronger overall leverage profiles, but the combination of velocity, power, and bat-missing ability gives Whritenour a realistic chance to move quickly through a professional bullpen.

Number 4: Tanner Bradley, RHP, Oregon

2026 Stats: 1.66 ERA | 59.1 IP | 90 K | 18 BB

Bradley ranks this highly because he possesses the type of singular weapon that can immediately translate into high-leverage professional innings. While many pitchers on this list derive value from overpowering velocity, Bradley succeeds through one of the most dominant changeups in the class and a pitch mix that becomes even more difficult to handle in shorter outings.

The changeup is the centerpiece of the profile and the primary reason he appears this high. Generating over 21 inches of arm-side movement while pairing it with negative induced vertical break, the pitch creates a movement profile hitters rarely encounter. More importantly, it produced elite swing-and-miss throughout 2026 and served as the defining pitch in the arsenal. In a bullpen role, where hitters may only see him once, the offering becomes even more difficult to identify and adjust to.

The sinker and sweeper provide valuable support. The sinker establishes the lower part of the strike zone and creates a different movement plane than the changeup, while the sweeper gives hitters another shape to consider. Neither pitch needs to carry the profile on its own. Their primary value is allowing the changeup to remain the focal point of the attack while preventing hitters from sitting on a single movement pattern.

Unlike some of the power relievers on this list, Bradley's success is built more on deception and movement than pure velocity. That creates a slightly different projection, but not necessarily a lesser one. Professional bullpens are filled with pitchers whose best weapon is a devastating offspeed pitch, and Bradley already possesses one of the best examples in the class.

Why #4: Bradley ranks this highly because truly elite carrying pitches are rare. The pitchers ranked above him possess louder velocity or more traditional leverage profiles, but few relievers in the class would enter professional baseball with a single weapon as capable of generating swing-and-miss as Bradley's changeup.

Number 3: Jackson Barberi, RHP, Florida

2026 Stats: 3.13 ERA | 37.1 IP | 1.018 WHIP | 55 K | 17 BB | 3.24 K:BB

Barberi ranks this highly because few pitchers in the class possess a clearer late-inning profile. The combination of elite velocity, a bat-missing slider, and a track record of dominating high-leverage situations gives him one of the easiest professional bullpen projections among the arms evaluated. While several pitchers ranked nearby are being projected into relief, Barberi has already shown he can thrive in that role against high-level competition.

The fastball is the foundation of everything. Sitting 97-99 mph and touching triple digits, the pitch combines elite ride with enough movement to consistently miss barrels. Even when hitters know it is coming, the velocity and carry create an extremely small margin for error. The pitch already performs like a professional leverage fastball and is capable of overwhelming hitters in short bursts.

The slider is what elevates the profile from power arm to legitimate bullpen weapon. Thrown in the mid-80s with sharp depth and quality command, it gives Barberi a true finishing pitch against hitters from both sides of the plate. The ability to throw it down and away to right-handed hitters while also back-footing and backdooring it to lefties allows him to avoid becoming a one-dimensional reliever.

Unlike some pitchers on this list, the bullpen projection is less about future role change and more about where the present strengths fit best. The fastball-slider combination is already good enough to generate outs in leverage situations, and the shorter workload allows both pitches to play at maximum intensity. The changeup still offers some long-term starter intrigue, but the profile currently looks most dangerous when condensed into shorter appearances.

Why #3: Barberi ranks this highly because elite velocity and a plus breaking ball remain the foundation of many successful professional bullpens. The pitchers ranked above him possess either rarer pitch traits or more unusual relief weapons, but few arms in the class project more naturally into high-leverage innings than Jackson Barberi.

Number 2: Sean Jenkins, RHP, ECU

2026 Stats: 2.61 ERA | 41.1 IP | 1.137 WHIP | 54 K | 12 BB

Jenkins ranks this highly because his profile already resembles that of a modern professional leverage reliever. Unlike many bullpen projections that rely on one dominant weapon, Jenkins attacks hitters with a devastating two-pitch combination built around a power sinker and power slider. Both pitches independently grade as plus offerings, and together they create one of the most difficult repertoires in the class to prepare for.

The slider is the headline pitch. Operating at 88-89 mph and touching 92, it lives in a velocity band rarely seen among collegiate breaking balls. The shape is deceptively simple, functioning as a hard gyro slider with late depth rather than an exaggerated sweeper. What makes the pitch special is not only the movement profile, but the combination of velocity, command, and contact management. Jenkins consistently located it beneath the zone against right-handed hitters while also demonstrating the ability to backdoor and bury it against lefties. The pitch generated elite swing-and-miss while still limiting quality contact when hitters managed to put it in play. The sinker elevates the profile from a good bullpen arm to a potentially dominant one. Sitting in the mid-90s with over 17 inches of arm-side movement, the pitch produces weak contact, ground balls, and uncomfortable swings even when left in competitive parts of the strike zone. Very few amateur relievers possess two pitches capable of carrying a professional bullpen role on their own.

The remaining developmental question revolves around the splitter. The fastball-slider foundation is already more than enough for leverage work, but a reliable third offering would create additional flexibility and potentially open the door for larger workloads. Even if that never materializes, however, the primary weapons already profile extremely well in relief.

Why #2: Jenkins ranks here because elite bullpen arms are often built around dominant pitch pairings, and few pitchers in the class can match the quality of his sinker-slider combination. The pitcher ranked above him possesses more individual impact weapons, but Jenkins already owns the type of repertoire that could close games at the professional level.

Number 1: Rhys Bowie, LHP, Wake Forest

2026 Stats: 5.22 ERA | 39.2 IP | 1.639 WHIP | 69 K | 32 BB

Bowie earns the top spot because no pitcher in the class possesses a more intimidating collection of bullpen weapons. While several arms on this list project comfortably into high-leverage relief roles, Bowie already features the type of arsenal professional organizations build entire late-inning plans around. Three fastball variants, two double-plus breaking balls, and upper-90s velocity from the left side give him a level of flexibility few relievers can match.

The foundation of the profile is the fastball combination. Bowie can attack hitters with a four-seam fastball, sinker, and cutter, each presenting a distinctly different look while maintaining premium velocity. That ability alone makes game-planning against him difficult, as hitters cannot simply eliminate a single fastball shape from consideration. Each offering serves a purpose and helps set up the rest of the arsenal.

The true separators, however, are the breaking balls. The curveball is the best breaking ball in the class and already projects as a professional out pitch. The cutter functions more like a power gyro slider and gives him another weapon capable of generating whiffs in leverage situations. Few pitchers possess one breaking ball capable of carrying a bullpen role. Bowie has two. That level of pitch quality dramatically raises the floor and ceiling of the profile.

The question is not whether the stuff will play. It is whether enough strikes will accompany it. Command inconsistency remains the primary obstacle between Bowie and a professional rotation role. In a bullpen, however, that concern becomes less significant. The ability to shorten outings and aggressively feature the best pitches allows the raw arsenal to take center stage.

Why #1: Bowie ranks first because high-leverage relievers are often defined by the quality of their weapons, and no pitcher in the class possesses more of them. Premium velocity, multiple fastball looks, and two double-plus breaking balls create the most complete leverage profile in the 2027 class. If the goal is getting the final three outs of a game, no arm I'd rather hand the baseball to.

Conclusion

Unlike starters, relievers are often defined by concentration rather than completeness.

A starter may need four or five quality offerings to navigate a lineup multiple times. A reliever only needs enough weapons to dominate for an inning or two. As a result, some of the most impactful professional bullpen arms are not necessarily the pitchers with the deepest arsenals. They are the pitchers whose best traits become overwhelming when condensed into shorter outings.

That concept appears repeatedly throughout this ranking. Rhys Bowie possesses enough raw stuff to dominate a lineup regardless of role, but the ability to concentrate multiple elite pitches into leverage situations makes the profile even more dangerous. Sean Jenkins' sinker-slider combination already resembles the foundation of a professional late-inning reliever. Jackson Barberi and Joshua Whritenour bring premium velocity that may play even louder when deployed without concern for pacing. Even pitchers such as Walker McDuffie, Lazaro Collera, and Tyler Guerin derive much of their value from a singular weapon capable of changing an at-bat immediately.

What stands out about this group is that there is no single bullpen archetype. Some succeed through velocity. Others through movement. Some rely on one dominant secondary, while others attack hitters with two distinct pitches that complement one another. The common thread is not how they record outs. It is their ability to record them quickly.

Many of these pitchers will continue pursuing starter roles throughout college and professional baseball. Some will succeed. Others will eventually find themselves in the bullpen, where their best traits can be featured more aggressively. In several cases, that move may increase rather than diminish their value.

The modern game places an enormous premium on leverage innings, and the 2027 class contains an unusual collection of pitchers capable of filling them. Whether it is Bowie's rare collection of power pitches, Jenkins' dominant sinker-slider pairing, or Bradley's elite changeup, each arm on this list possesses at least one trait that can survive the jump to professional baseball. In the right role, several have a chance to become far more than simply another bullpen arm.

Ultimately, the best relievers are often the pitchers who force quick decisions from hitters. This group contains some of the most uncomfortable decisions in the entire 2027 class.